THE 2027 CYCLE STARTS IN OCTOBER. YOUR RATING DOES NOT.

The 2027 Appraisal Playbook

Get the rating, the hike and the promotion you have already earned.

A brag document, a self-appraisal skeleton, a one-page promotion case, the negotiation script, the CTC decoder and eight AI prompts.
India edition · 2026-27 cycle · verified October 2026

15 parts · 40 pages · 8 AI prompts · 7 worksheets · no filler

9.1%
projected average increment for 2027

5.54%
September 2026 CPI inflation

~3.4%
what is left of it after inflation

Sources: Aon Annual Salary Increase and Turnover Survey 2025-26; Deloitte India Talent Outlook 2026; EY Future of Pay 2026; MoSPI CPI for September 2026; RBI Monetary Policy Statement, 7 October 2026.

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What is inside

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How to read this in twenty minutes

If you are short of time, read Part 2 for the money reality and Part 8 for what a hike is actually worth, then fill in the negotiation prep sheet in Part 13. That is enough to have a better conversation this month. Everything else is for the person who intends to change the outcome of the cycle, and that needs the calendar in Part 3 and the brag document in Part 4.

1 Read This First

What this book does, what it does not, and how to use it in twenty minutes

This book answers one question: **how do I turn the work I have already done into a better rating, a bigger hike and a promotion, in this cycle, in an Indian company?**

It is not a book about working harder, and it is not a book about office politics. It is about a mechanical problem most salaried Indians lose every year without noticing. You did the work. Your manager is filling appraisal forms for eight to fifteen people from memory, in a two-week window, while also doing their own job. Into that room walks whoever handed them a clean, numbered, one-page case. The rest walk in as an impression.

So the book is mostly templates: a brag document, a self-appraisal skeleton, a one-page promotion case, a negotiation sheet, a CTC decoder and eight AI prompts that do the drafting for you. Every one of them is built to be filled in, not read.

Why the timing matters more than the tactics

Most Indian companies run one appraisal cycle a year, with the revised salary effective from 1 April or 1 July. The increment pool is finalised between January and March. That means the number that decides your year is set roughly six months before you find out what it is, and the only window in which you can influence it is the one you are in now.

As of 29 October 2026, the 2027 cycle has already started. Reporting on 20 October 2026 confirmed that companies have begun work on hikes, promotions and bonuses for 2027, with consultants projecting roughly flat budgets and recruiters expecting rewards to be concentrated on top performers and AI-skilled talent. You are roughly ten to fourteen weeks from the point where your manager writes down a rating. That is enough time to build evidence. It is not enough time to build a reputation.

What is verified here, and what is judgement

Every number attributed to a survey, a regulator or a law in this book was checked against the publisher's own release, and the source and date are listed in Part 15. Where a figure is an estimate or my opinion, it says so in the sentence. Nothing here is copied from a careers blog, because those pages are almost always recycled from each other and rarely dated.

Two things in particular are stated plainly because they change the arithmetic of your year: India's inflation print for September 2026 was 5.54%, and the average increment budget for 2027 is projected at about 9%. Both are official or first-party figures. Together they mean the average salaried Indian is being offered roughly a 3% real increase, before tax.

Three ways to use this book

If you have	Do this	Time
20 minutes	Read Part 2 (the money reality) and fill in the Negotiation Prep Sheet in Part 13. You will know your number and your floor before you talk to anyone.	20 min
One evening	Parts 2 to 5. Reconstruct the last twelve months, write twelve brag entries and draft your self-appraisal using the skeleton.	2-3 hrs

If you have	Do this	Time
The full cycle	Read it once now, then work the month-by-month calendar in Part 3 through to your April letter. This is the version that changes the outcome.	Oct to Apr

The one thing that decides most outcomes
Ratings and increments are decided in a calibration meeting you are not in. The only thing you can put in that room is a document. If your year exists only in your manager's memory, you are competing against whoever remembered to write theirs down.

2 The 2027 Money Reality

What the surveys actually project, what inflation does to it, and why the pool is not your number

Before you negotiate, you need to know what is being negotiated over. Three things are true at once in the 2027 cycle, and most people only know the first one.

First: the pool is flat, at about 9%

Aon's Annual Salary Increase and Turnover Survey, now in its 32nd edition and covering more than 1,400 organisations across 45 industries, projected a 9.1% average increase for India in 2026, up from an actual 8.9% in 2025. Deloitte's India Talent Outlook 2026 landed on the same 9.1%, against 9.0% in 2025. EY's Future of Pay 2026 also projected 9.1%.

For 2027, the direction is flat. Reporting on 20 October 2026 put Aon's 2027 projection at 9.1% nominal, in line with 2026, while Deloitte and WTW expect average increases to remain flat and recruiters at ABC Consultants expect banking increments of 6% to 7% in FY27 against 8% to 9% in FY26. The same reporting flagged a structural shift worth more attention than the headline: one-time bonuses replacing permanent salary hikes, as companies reward people without raising fixed costs.

Aon projected increments, 2026	2025 actual	2026 projected
Overall India	8.9%	9.1%
Real estate and infrastructure	10.5%	10.2%
NBFCs	9.7%	10.1%
Automotive and vehicle manufacturing	9.8%	9.9%
Engineering design services	10.0%	9.9%
Engineering and manufacturing	9.4%	9.5%
Retail	9.0%	9.5%
Energy (oil, gas, power)	9.3%	9.4%
Life sciences	9.3%	9.4%
Technology platform and products	9.2%	9.4%
Global capability centres	9.2%	9.3%
FMCG	8.9%	9.1%
Banking	8.4%	8.8%
E-commerce	8.7%	8.8%
Funds and asset management	9.7%	8.5%
Chemicals	8.5%	8.3%
Life insurance	8.2%	8.2%
Technology consulting and services	7.0%	6.6%

Source: Aon, Annual Salary Increase and Turnover Survey 2025-26 India, released 24 February 2026. Aon's 2027 projection, reported 20 October 2026, is 9.1% overall with NBFCs at 10.1%, energy at 9.9% and real estate and infrastructure at 9.8%.

Second: the differentiation is sharper than it was

A flat pool with sharper differentiation is a different game from a flat pool with uniform rises. Deloitte's 2026 survey found the share of employees receiving the highest rating on a five-point scale fell from 10% in 2024 to 7% in 2025, while about 16% of the workforce sat in the bottom two categories. Promotions ran at about 14%, nearly double the share of top-rated performers, which tells you companies are paying for future potential as well as past performance.

Aon's data points the same way: top performers received 2.24 times the variable pay and 1.85 times the salary increase of average performers. EY put the premium on AI, machine learning, cybersecurity and cloud skills at 30% to 40%, with top performers earning up to 1.6 times more through targeted rewards.

The practical translation: **in a 9% pool, the difference between a 7% and a 13% outcome is not effort, it is placement.** Two people with identical output can land on either side of that gap depending entirely on which of them was legible in the calibration room.

Third: inflation has eaten the headline

India's consumer price inflation for September 2026 was 5.54%, with food inflation at 7.74%, according to the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation release of 12 October 2026. The Reserve Bank of India raised the repo rate by 25 basis points to 5.50% on 7 October 2026, its first increase since February 2023, changed its stance to calibrated tightening, and projected CPI inflation at 5.2% for FY 2026-27 with an average near 5.8% across the next three quarters. The next Monetary Policy Committee meeting is scheduled for 2 to 4 December 2026.

Now do the arithmetic that no increment letter does for you. The real increase is not the difference between your old and new salary; it is that difference adjusted for prices:

> **The real-hike formula (Fisher equation)**
> Real hike % = [(1 + nominal hike %) / (1 + inflation %)] - 1
>
> 9.1% nominal, 5.54% inflation -> (1.091 / 1.0554) - 1 = 3.37% real
> 9.1% nominal, 5.20% inflation -> (1.091 / 1.0520) - 1 = 3.71% real
> 7.0% nominal, 5.54% inflation -> (1.070 / 1.0554) - 1 = 1.38% real
> 6.6% nominal, 5.54% inflation -> (1.066 / 1.0554) - 1 = 1.00% real

Read that again. An employee in technology consulting and services, the sector Aon puts at 6.6% for 2026, is being offered a real increase of about 1%. After income tax, for anyone above the rebate threshold, it is closer to nothing. This is not an argument for despair; it is the argument for asking. You are not asking for a reward. You are asking for a correction against a 5.5% price level, and the only person who will make that case with your numbers in it is you.

Nominal hike	Real at 5.54% CPI	Real at 6.00% CPI	What it means in one line
6.6%	1.00%	0.57%	A flat year wearing a percentage
8.0%	2.33%	1.89%	Barely ahead of prices
9.1%	3.37%	2.92%	The average, and it is thin

Nominal hike	Real at 5.54% CPI	Real at 6.00% CPI	What it means in one line
12.0%	6.12%	5.66%	A genuinely good year
15.0%	8.96%	8.49%	Strong performer territory
20.0%	13.70%	13.21%	Promotion or a switch

What this changes about your ask

- **Never ask for 'a good hike'.** Ask for a number, and put the real-hike arithmetic next to it. '9% is the pool; at 5.54% inflation that is 3.4% real. I am asking for 13%, which is 7% real, and here is why the scope supports it.'
- **Value fixed pay above variable.** With variable pay rising as a share of CTC and companies increasingly using one-time bonuses instead of permanent increases, a 7% fixed increase plus a 15% variable target is not the same offer as a flat 10% fixed. The first is a target; the second is money, and it compounds into your next hike, your PF and your gratuity.
- **Ask early.** A February conversation with data is leverage. A May conversation after the letter is an exception request, and exceptions are rare, slow and remembered.

> **The sentence to remember**
> Your company has a 9% pool. Your job is not to argue with the pool. Your job is to be the person the pool is spent on.

3 The Calendar

What the company is doing each month, what you should be doing, and the document it produces

Appraisal cycles are not mysterious, they are just invisible from below. Here is the standard Indian cycle for a company with an April effective date, mapped month by month from today. If your cycle runs July to June, shift everything forward by three months; the sequence is identical.

When	What the company is doing	What you do	The artefact
Late Oct to Nov 2026	HR drafts the increment budget. Managers are asked for initial recommendations. Promotion nominations open at many firms. Reporting on 20 October 2026 confirms this work has begun.	Start the brag document. Reconstruct the year in one sitting (Part 4). Open the promotion conversation now, not in February.	Brag document, 12 entries
December 2026	Finance stress-tests the pool against cost pressure, with the RBI's 7 October rate hike and a 5.54% inflation print in the background. Some firms run a mid-year check-in.	Ask the one question that shapes everything: 'What would need to be true for me to be in the top band this cycle?' Write down the answer verbatim.	The answer, in writing, in your own notes
January 2027	The self-appraisal window opens. Managers submit draft ratings and budget requests. This is where the number is effectively set.	Submit the self-appraisal early, not on the deadline. Hand your manager the one-page brief separately, before calibration.	Self-appraisal, plus the one-page brief
February to March 2027	Calibration and normalisation across teams. Ratings are forced into a distribution. Budgets lock.	Almost nothing new lands here. Do not open a new negotiation. If you must, ask for a specific mid-year review date instead.	The booked mid-year review
April 2027	Letters are issued, effective 1 April. Some companies run a 1 July effective date.	Separate the rating conversation from the money conversation. Do the increment discussion in its own meeting, with the sheet from Part 13.	Negotiation prep sheet, then the follow-up email
May to July 2027	The pool is spent. Only exceptions and retention cases move now.	If you won partially, bank the written commitments. If you did not, run the outside option on your own timeline, not as a threat.	Offer comparison sheet

The four dates to put in your calendar today

1. **This week:** one 45-minute session to reconstruct the last twelve months. Nothing else in this book works without it.

2. **Within ten days:** the promotion conversation, if you are targeting one. Two months before the cycle is the accepted minimum; you are already at the edge of it.

3. **December 2026:** the 'what would need to be true' question, asked in a scheduled one-to-one and written down.

4. **Two weeks before your self-appraisal deadline:** the one-page brief to your manager, sent as a separate note, not inside the form.

If your company says it has no bell curve

Many large Indian firms have publicly dropped forced ranking while continuing to operate a fixed salary pool and a lighter calibration for the final increment. The practical effect for you is identical: someone decides how the pool is split. Whether that decision is called calibration, normalisation or a talent review changes the vocabulary, not the arithmetic. Prepare as if there is a distribution, because there is a budget, and a budget is a distribution with a nicer name.

> **The mistake that costs the most**
> Most people start preparing in January, when the form arrives. By then the rating is being drafted and the pool is being requested. January is for submission, not for influence.

4 The Brag Document

The five-minute Friday habit that makes every other page in this book possible

A brag document is a private list of what you did and what it produced, written as it happens, in language you can paste into a form. Keep it in your personal drive, not on company systems. Nobody else has to see it, and the version you show your manager is a filtered extract.

The reason it works is not motivational. It is that memory is a poor witness. Ask yourself what you shipped in March and you will produce a vague answer; ask what you shipped last week and you will produce a specific one. Twelve months of that gap is where good years disappear.

The entry formula

> **One line, four parts**
> ACTION + NUMBER + SCOPE + LASTING EFFECT
>
> Action - what you actually did, in a verb, past tense
> Number - the change it produced, in rupees, hours, percent, days or count
> Scope - how big the surface was: services, people, clients, months, geographies
> Lasting - what is still true because of it: a standard, a runbook, a person now independent

If you cannot attach a number, attach a scope or a durability. 'Became the team's standard approach and has been used twice since by other engineers' is a legitimate impact statement without a rupee figure in it.

Activity language versus impact language

This is the single most common weakness in Indian self-appraisals. Activity language tells your manager you were busy. Impact language tells them you mattered. The rewrite is mechanical, which is why the AI prompts in Part 12 work so well on it.

Instead of this (activity)	Write this (impact)
Worked on improving the deployment pipeline and fixed several issues.	Rebuilt the deployment pipeline, cutting release time from 45 minutes to 11 and raising release frequency from two a week to five.
Helped the team during incidents and participated in on-call.	Led three P1 incidents with a mean time to resolve under 40 minutes each, and wrote the escalation runbook the team now uses.
Supported junior team members.	Mentored two engineers who now handle L2 on-call independently, removing roughly six hours of escalation from my week.
Handled client escalations.	Took over month-end escalations for four accounts worth about 18% of branch revenue, with zero escalations to my manager in Q3.
Responsible for MIS reporting.	Rebuilt the weekly MIS in a single sheet, cutting preparation from four hours to forty minutes and removing three manual reconciliations.
Was involved in the vendor selection.	Ran the vendor evaluation for the logistics contract across six bidders and recommended the option that reduced per-shipment cost by 11%.

Instead of this (activity)	Write this (impact)
Coordinated with multiple stakeholders.	Ran the fortnightly cross-team forum for three teams and four vendors, which closed 23 open dependencies in two quarters.
Completed the training programme.	Completed the certification and applied it to migrate two workloads, which the team now runs without external support.
Took initiative on process improvement.	Introduced a pre-upgrade checklist after the Q3 rollback, which has since been used for two upgrades with no incidents.
Managed social media.	Moved posting to a fixed weekly calendar, which lifted reach 34% and cut agency dependency for day-to-day content.
Assisted in hiring.	Interviewed 41 candidates for four roles and closed three of them in under 30 days, against a team average of 52.
Handled customer queries.	Reduced first-response time from nine hours to under two across the support inbox, with a satisfaction score that held at 4.6 of 5.

The four buckets every brag document needs

People over-index on the first bucket and forget the other three, which is exactly backwards, because the other three are what a manager can defend when challenged.

Bucket	What goes in it	Why it survives calibration
Shipped work	Projects delivered, features launched, deadlines met or beaten.	It is checkable. Anyone can verify it happened.
Money	Revenue influenced, cost saved, leakage stopped, hours recovered and what they were worth.	Finance language travels further than effort language in any review room.
People	Mentoring, onboarding, hiring, unblocking others, covering for someone.	It shows you made the team's output larger than your own, which is the definition of the next level.
Reliability	The unglamorous work: reviews, recurring reporting, the tedious cross-team coordination, the thing that made your manager's quarter easier.	It is the most under-reported and most appreciated category. Managers fight for the person who made their week lighter.

Things people forget to log, and always should

- Praise, quoted. When someone thanks you in writing, paste the sentence and the date. A client sentence is worth three self-descriptions.
- Incidents you led, including the ones that ended quietly.
- Anything you unblocked for someone else. It is invisible in your own output and highly visible in theirs.
- Documents other people now use: runbooks, templates, checklists, SOPs, dashboards.
- Hiring: interviews taken, roles closed, time to fill.
- Onboarding: who you brought up to speed and how fast.
- Decisions you made that prevented a problem, which by definition produced no incident to point at.
- Scope you absorbed quietly: a person who left, a client that was added, a system you inherited.

The 45-minute reconstruction exercise

You do not need to remember the year. You need to re-read it. Do this once, today, in three passes:

1. **Calendar pass (15 min).** Scroll your work calendar month by month. Every recurring meeting you owned, every launch, every review, every trip. Write a stub next to each month.

2. **Sent-mail pass (15 min).** Search your sent folder for the words: delivered, completed, closed, launched, saved, reduced, approved, signed off, resolved. Skim only the subject lines.

3. **Documents pass (15 min).** Open the shared drive and look at what has your name on it. Decks, sheets, specs, policies, proposals.

You will end with 20 to 40 stubs. Convert the best twelve into full entries using the formula. Twelve is enough. Nobody reads more than twelve, and your manager cannot carry more than three into a room.

> **A note on honesty**
> Do not inflate. Every number in a brag document can be checked by someone in the room, and one exaggeration discredits the nine true entries next to it. Where a number is an estimate, write 'approximately' and be ready to explain the basis.

5 The Self-Appraisal

How to write the document that anchors your rating, in 600 to 900 words

The self-appraisal is the only document in the process that you fully control, and it is read in a hurry by someone who has fifteen of them to get through. Two consequences follow. First, it has to be scannable. Second, the first claim in it matters more than the tenth, because people anchor on what they read first and adjust from there. That is a well-established effect in judgement and negotiation research, and it applies to a form as much as to a salary figure.

The structure that works

Six sections, in this order. The word budget in brackets is a ceiling, not a target.

1. **Opening (60 words).** One line on what the year was about, then your self-rating claim. Not a summary of duties; a claim with a spine.

2. **Three to five achievements (60 to 90 words each).** Impact language, one number each, and the lasting effect. Lead with the one that carries the most money or the most risk.

3. **One honest challenge (80 words).** A real failure, owned, with the process that now prevents it. This section builds more trust than any other, and leaving it out makes the document read as self-serving.

4. **How you worked with others (60 words).** Mentoring, unblocking, cross-team work. This is where the next-level signal lives.

5. **Three goals for next year (60 words).** Each with a metric and a month. Vague goals read as someone who has not thought about the next level.

6. **What you need (40 words, optional).** One or two specific asks: a stretch project, a sponsor, a budget. Specific, small, and easy to say yes to.

Total: 600 to 900 words. Longer does not read as thorough, it reads as unedited, and it pushes the three things you need remembered out of view.

The failure paragraph, in one formula

> **Five sentences, no self-flagellation**
>
> 1. What happened, with the number. 'The Q3 migration required a partial rollback.'
> 2. What it cost. 'It added six hours of unplanned work and delayed two dependent releases by three days.'
> 3. What I own, specifically. 'The staging validation for stateful services was incomplete, and that was my call.'
> 4. The process that now prevents it. 'I introduced a pre-upgrade checklist requiring staging sign-off for stateful services.'
> 5. Evidence it works. 'It has been used for two upgrades since, with no incidents.'

What not to write: a failure with no cost (reads as a humblebrag), a failure blamed on another team (reads as a risk), or a failure with no forward fix (reads as a pattern).

Fourteen weak phrases, and what to write instead

Weak	Strong
Was involved in	Led / built / shipped / owned
Helped with	Delivered the X part of, which produced Y
Responsible for	Ran, and the result was
Worked on	Cut / raised / closed / reduced
Assisted	Took over when needed and delivered
Participated in	Contributed the specific piece that
Supported the team	Unblocked three people on, which released
Handled	Resolved N of M within X days
Various	Name them, with counts
Successfully completed	Completed, and the effect was
Took initiative on	Proposed, got approval, and delivered
Coordinated	Ran the forum that closed N dependencies
Was part of a team that	Owned the X workstream inside a team that
As per	Delete the phrase and state the fact

How to state a self-rating without sounding arrogant

Most Indian employees write 'I would rate myself 4' and then apologise for it in the next sentence. Do the opposite: state the claim, then attach evidence to the expectation it maps to.

> **The self-rating paragraph**
> On our five-point scale I believe my year maps to a 4. Taking the expectations for my level one at a time: on delivery, I closed 14 of 15 committed items and the one that slipped was re-scoped with your agreement in August. On quality, defect escape rate fell from 4.1% to 1.6%. On ownership, I took over the reporting module when Ramesh left and it has run without escalation for two quarters. On people, I mentored two engineers who now handle L2 independently. The gap I would name myself is stakeholder communication on the vendor programme, which I have addressed by taking the fortnightly forum.

Notice what that paragraph does. It makes a claim, it maps to stated criteria rather than to feelings, and it names its own gap before anyone else can. That last move is what makes the rest credible.

A complete example, for an analyst

Here is a full self-appraisal, written the way it should be. Names and numbers are illustrative; the structure is the point.

> *Year in one line. This was the year I moved from producing the monthly business review to owning the forecast that sits under it, and the numbers moved in the right direction while the reporting workload fell. On our five-point scale I believe my year maps to a 4, and the evidence is below.*

1. Rebuilt the monthly forecast, which cut variance from 11% to 3.4%. I replaced the spreadsheet model with a driver-based one built on the last eighteen months of actuals, validated it against two quarters of history, and presented the error analysis to the leadership review in June. Forecast accuracy improved from 89% to 96.6% on revenue, which reduced the buffer the regional team carries for shortfalls. The model is now the standard for the north and west regions, and my documentation is what the two new analysts were trained on.

2. Cut the monthly reporting cycle by two working days. I consolidated four reports into one sheet with a single source of truth, removing three manual reconciliations that consumed about eleven hours a month. Close now finishes on day three instead of day five, which gives the sales team two extra days to act inside the month.

3. Took over the pricing analysis for the SMB segment. When Priya moved to the corporate team in April, I absorbed the SMB pricing pack with no additional headcount. I rebuilt it at transaction level, identified a discounting pattern in two states that was costing approximately 1.8% of segment margin, and the revised approval matrix was implemented in August.

4. What went wrong. In Q2 I presented a forecast to the regional review without checking the revised channel-mix assumption with the supply team, and the number was challenged in the meeting. It cost credibility for about a month. I now run a mandatory fifteen-minute check with supply before any number leaves my desk, and the last three reviews have had no challenges on data.

5. Working with others. I trained two new analysts on the forecast model and the close calendar, both of whom now run their regions independently. I also took over the fortnightly analytics forum for four months while the lead was on leave.

6. Next year. Extend the driver model to the corporate segment by June. Automate the reconciliation step that still consumes about three hours a month, by March. And take the commercial-finance certification, which I have asked to have sponsored.

That is 480 words. It makes one claim, proves it four times, owns one failure with a fix, shows the next-level behaviour, and states what it wants. It will be read in ninety seconds and remembered.

> **The three things that ruin a self-appraisal**
> A task list instead of achievements. No numbers anywhere. And apologising for your own results ('I was fortunate that the team supported me') — gratitude belongs in the acknowledgements, not in the evidence.

6 The Rating Game

How the decision is actually made, and what to hand the person making it

The standard cycle runs: self-review, manager review and rating, calibration or normalisation across teams, then the increment and promotion decision. Calibration exists to keep ratings consistent between lenient and strict managers, and it is also where the distribution appears.

Three numbers, all from 2026 surveys, describe the room you are competing in. The share of employees getting the highest rating fell to 7%, from 10% the year before. About 16% sit in the bottom two categories. Promotions ran at roughly 14%, nearly twice the top-rating share. Deloitte's reading is that companies are rewarding both current performance and future potential, while trying to avoid title inflation.

The implication is uncomfortable and useful: **the top band is smaller than it was, so being excellent is no longer the differentiator. Being the person your manager can defend is.**

What the room needs, and what you can supply

What the room asks	What your manager needs from you	What you hand over
'What did they deliver?'	A number, not a narrative.	The brag document extract: three achievements, each with a figure.
'Compared to whom?'	A sense of where you sit against the band and the level above.	One line on scope: what you own now that you did not own a year ago.
'Will they leave?'	A credible, non-dramatic signal of market value.	The benchmark range you found, mentioned once, calmly.
'Give me one sentence.'	A story short enough to repeat from memory.	The one-sentence story, written for them, in their words.

The one-sentence story

This is the highest-leverage thing in the book and it takes four minutes. Write the sentence your manager will say about you when someone else's name comes up. It has three parts: the change you made, the size of it, and what it means for the business.

Role	The one-sentence story
Engineer	He rebuilt our release pipeline, so we ship five times a week instead of two, and nothing has broken since.
Sales	She took the two accounts nobody wanted and turned them into 18% of branch revenue.
Operations	He cut our month-end close from five days to three, which gave sales two extra selling days a month.
HR	She closed four roles in under 30 days when the team average was 52, and three of them are still with us.
Analyst	He rebuilt the forecast and our variance dropped from 11% to under 4%.
Manager	He made his team's on-call bearable, and nobody on it has resigned in a year.

Give your manager this sentence explicitly. Say: 'If it is useful when you talk about my year, the one line I would use is this.' You are not being naive. You are removing the work of composing it from a busy person's

evening.

Visibility without politics

The word 'visibility' makes honest people uncomfortable, usually because they hear 'self-promotion'. It is not. Visibility is the difference between work that exists and work that is known to exist, and in a distributed team it is a genuine skill, not a trick. Four low-cost habits:

- **The five-line Friday.** One short note to your manager: what moved, what is blocked, what you need. It takes three minutes and it means your manager never has to reconstruct your week.
- **One artefact leadership reads.** Not a status update; a document with a number in the title. 'Cutting close from five days to three' travels; 'Monthly MIS update' does not.
- **The written decision record.** When you make a call that matters, write five lines on what you decided and why. It is the only durable evidence that the judgement was yours.
- **The thank-you you ask for.** When you unblock someone, ask them to copy your manager when they thank you. That is not vanity; it is the only mechanism by which cross-team work becomes visible to the person who rates you.

Three situations that need handling in advance

You joined mid-year. Ask, in writing, what the pro-rated expectation is. A manager rating a seven-month year against a twelve-month bar is a structural disadvantage, and the time to fix the bar is before the form opens.

You changed manager. Your new manager did not see your year and will rate you on their impression of two quarters. Give them the brag document extract in your first month, framed as context rather than a claim: 'so you have the history when the cycle comes'.

You are going on maternity leave. Maternity benefit is 26 weeks of paid leave for the first and second child under the Code on Social Security, which came into force on 21 November 2025. Before you go, agree in writing how your targets and rating will be pro-rated. A leave that spans an appraisal cycle without a written agreement about the cycle is how strong years quietly become average ones.

> **What not to do**
> Do not compare yourself to a named colleague in any written document or meeting. It converts an evidence conversation into a fairness argument, and fairness arguments are settled by whoever holds the budget. Compare yourself to the band, the level above, and the market.

7 The Money Conversation

The script, the sequence, and what to ask for when the answer is 'budget is fixed'

Two conversations are being conflated in most appraisal meetings, and separating them is the single biggest structural improvement you can make. The rating conversation is about performance. The increment conversation is about money. They have different evidence, different timing and different failure modes. Conflating them means the rating, once stated, sets a ceiling on the money before you have said a word.

So: accept the rating, or push back on it specifically, and then ask for a separate meeting on compensation once you have reviewed market data. 'I would like to schedule a separate conversation about the increment, once I have had a chance to look at the benchmarks for my role' is a complete sentence and it costs nothing.

Timing

Four to eight weeks before the cycle closes is the window where a manager can still put a number into a request. The most effective sequence, in the words of the practitioners who write about it: benchmark in November and December, document impact in January, request the career conversation in February framed as growth rather than demand, and anchor the expectation before the budget is submitted. Raising it in May is asking for an exception. Exceptions exist, but they are rarer, slower and remembered.

The five-part script

> **Structure before wording**
>
> 1. Context - one sentence on why you asked for the meeting. No apology.
> 2. Evidence - two or three results, each with a number, in the order that matters most.
> 3. Scope - what you own now that you did not own a year ago.
> 4. The ask - a specific number or range, with a named source. Put it on the table yourself.
> 5. The question - 'Is that something you can support, and if not, what would need to be true?'

Part four is where most people fail. They describe their year beautifully and then say 'so I was hoping for a good increment'. A hope is not an anchor. A number is, and the first specific number put on the table pulls the outcome toward it.

The full script, adapted for India

Fill in the brackets. Keep it under two minutes before you stop talking and let them respond.

The conversation

"Thanks for making time. I want to talk about my compensation in this cycle, and I want to do it with data rather than feelings, so I have written down three things."

"First, the year. I took over the reporting module when Ramesh left and it has run for two quarters without an escalation. I cut the weekly report from four hours to forty minutes. And I handled the client's month-end escalations on my own through Q3, which is about 18% of branch revenue."

"Second, the scope. My job description has not changed since I joined, but I am now doing the reporting ownership and the client escalation piece, which were two separate roles last year."

"Third, the number. Aon's survey puts the 2027 average increase in India at 9.1%, and retail at about 9.5%. For similar roles in Pune I am seeing a fixed range of 9 to 11 lakh. I am currently at 8.4 lakh fixed. I am asking for a revision to 9.6 lakh fixed in this cycle."

"Is that something you can support? And if not, what would need to be true by the next review for it to be possible?"

- then stop talking, and write down the answer verbatim -

The short version, for a manager with eight minutes: 'Three results, one scope change, one number, one question.' If you cannot compress it to ninety seconds you have not decided what the ask is.

When the answer is 'budget is fixed'

It usually is, and it is usually true. That does not mean the conversation is over; it means the currency has changed. Work down this list in order of value to you, not in order of ease:

Ask	Why it is worth having	What to say
A written mid-year review date	It converts a refusal into a dated commitment, and a dated commitment is hard to forget.	'Can we put a review in the calendar for July, and can you tell me what I need to show by then?'
One-time retention bonus	Companies are increasingly using one-time payments in place of permanent increases. It is real money and often available when a hike is not.	'If the fixed budget is closed, is there a one-time payment available in this cycle?'
Title or band change	It compounds. A band change resets the base your future percentages are calculated on.	'If the increment is not possible, can the designation and band move, with the money following at the next cycle?'
Employer NPS contribution	An employer contribution to NPS up to 14% of basic plus DA is exempt in your hands under the new regime, subject to the combined ₹7.5 lakh annual cap on employer PF, NPS and superannuation. It is money that never appears as taxable salary.	'Can my structure include an employer NPS contribution, and what would it take to add it?'
Certification or education budget	A funded credential is a permanent asset, and it is usually in a different budget line from salary.	'Is there an L&D budget I can use for the certification, and would you sponsor it?'
Additional leave or remote days	Worth a measurable amount to you and often free to the company.	'If money is closed, is there flexibility on additional leave this year?'

Ask	Why it is worth having	What to say
A written commitment with criteria	The weakest option, but better than a verbal promise, because it creates an artefact.	'Can you confirm in an email what the criteria are, so I am working to the right bar?'

The follow-up email, sent the same day

> **Five lines, no emotion**
>
> Subject: Summary of our conversation today
>
> Hi [Manager],
>
> Thank you for the discussion. To confirm what I understood: my rating for the year is [X], and the increment position is [Y], with [Z] to be reviewed at [date].
>
> The three points I raised were [one line each]. If I have misrecorded anything, please correct me.
>
> Regards, [Name]

Send it even when the conversation went well, and especially when it did not. A contemporaneous summary is the difference between a verbal position and a documented one, and it takes four minutes.

Four things not to say

- Your personal expenses. Rent, a wedding, a loan, a child's school fee. All true, all irrelevant to the person holding a budget, and all of them move the conversation from value to need.
- A named colleague's salary. It turns evidence into grievance and invites a confidentiality problem you cannot win.
- An ultimatum you will not keep. If you say you will leave and then stay, every future conversation is priced accordingly.
- 'I know everyone is getting 9%, but I want more.' Correct and still badly framed: it makes your ask sound like a demand for special treatment rather than a case built on scope.

> **If you manage people, read this bit**
> The same five-part structure works upward. Write a five-line brief for each person you are recommending: name, the one-sentence story, the number, the scope change, and the risk if the answer is no. Managers who bring written cases get more of the pool than managers who bring opinions, because the person above them has to defend a list, and a list with reasons in it is easier to defend.

8 Decode the CTC

What the hike is actually worth after tax, PF and the 2026 wage rules

An increment letter quotes cost to company. Your bank account receives something else. Three layers sit between them: what counts as salary, what is deducted, and what is taxed. Getting these wrong means negotiating for a number that does not arrive.

Layer one: CTC is not salary

Four lines inside your CTC never reach your hand: the employer's PF contribution, the gratuity provision, group insurance premium, and any variable pay that has not been earned yet. When someone says '10% hike', ask which of these moved. A hike that lands entirely in the variable target is not a hike; it is a target, and Aon's data shows variable pay is a rising share of fixed compensation, with senior management structures running variable at up to 40% of CTC.

Layer two: the 2026 wage rules changed the structure

India's four labour codes came into force on 21 November 2025 and consolidated 29 central labour statutes. The change that affects your payslip is the uniform definition of wages: basic pay, dearness allowance and retaining allowance must together be at least 50% of total remuneration, and if allowances exceed that ceiling the excess is added back for statutory purposes.

Since most private-sector employees have no DA or retaining allowance, the practical effect is that basic pay has had to rise toward 50% of CTC, where it historically sat at 25% to 40%. Because PF is 12% of basic plus DA and gratuity is 15 days of wages per completed year, both calculations now run on a larger base. Take-home can dip slightly while retirement savings and gratuity rise. The Ministry of Labour and Employment confirmed in its March 2026 FAQ that the 50% rule applies from 21 November 2025.

Statutory item	Rate or rule	Threshold
Employees' Provident Fund	12% employer plus 12% employee, on basic plus DA	Wage ceiling ₹15,000 per month
Employees' State Insurance	3.25% employer plus 0.75% employee, on gross wages	₹21,000 per month
Gratuity	15 days of wages per completed year, divisor 26	5 years permanent; 1 year for fixed-term
Employer NPS contribution	Up to 14% of basic plus DA, exempt in your hands	Combined PF, NPS and superannuation cap ₹7.5 lakh a year
Gratuity tax exemption	Statutory portion exempt	₹20 lakh lifetime cap

Sources: Code on Wages 2019 and Code on Social Security 2020, in force 21 November 2025; Ministry of Labour and Employment FAQ, March 2026; 2026 employee benefits reference for rates and ceilings.

Layer three: income tax for FY 2026-27

FY 2026-27 is the first year under the Income-tax Act, 2025, which replaced the 1961 Act on 1 April 2026. The law now calls the year a tax year rather than an assessment year, and the section numbers changed, but the amounts did not: Budget 2026 left personal income tax untouched. The rebate that was Section 87A is now Section 156, and the new regime that was Section 115BAC is now Section 202.

Total income (new regime, FY 2026-27)	Rate
Up to ₹4,00,000	Nil
₹4,00,001 to ₹8,00,000	5%
₹8,00,001 to ₹12,00,000	10%
₹12,00,001 to ₹16,00,000	15%
₹16,00,001 to ₹20,00,000	20%
₹20,00,001 to ₹24,00,000	25%
Above ₹24,00,000	30%

- **Standard deduction:** ₹75,000 for salaried individuals and pensioners, applied automatically.
- **Rebate:** up to ₹60,000 under Section 156 if total income is ₹12 lakh or less. Combined with the standard deduction, a salaried person earning up to ₹12.75 lakh pays no income tax.
- **Marginal relief:** just above ₹12 lakh, tax is capped at the amount by which your income exceeds ₹12 lakh, so ₹12.10 lakh of taxable income pays ₹10,000 rather than ₹61,500.
- **Cess:** 4% health and education cess on tax. Surcharge starts above ₹50 lakh, capped at 25% in the new regime.
- **Excluded from the rebate:** tax on special-rate income such as long-term capital gains, which is calculated separately.

The trap at the ₹12 lakh line

This is the single most useful piece of arithmetic in the book for anyone earning between ₹11 lakh and ₹14 lakh. Marginal relief is not a smooth curve; it ends. With these slabs, relief helps until taxable income reaches roughly ₹12.7 lakh, after which normal slab tax is lower than the excess and relief stops applying. The effect is that a hike which carries you across that band can cost you more in tax than the hike is worth in the first part of the journey.

> **Worked example: a 9.1% hike across the cliff**
>
> Taxable income now ₹12,40,000
> Slab tax: 20,000 + 40,000 + (40,000 x 15%) ₹66,000
> Marginal relief caps tax at the excess over 12L ₹40,000
> Tax payable with 4% cess ₹41,600
>
> After a 9.1% hike, taxable income ₹13,52,840
> Slab tax: 20,000 + 40,000 + (1,52,840 x 15%) ₹82,926
> Excess over 12L is 1,52,840, more than the tax, so no relief
> Tax payable with 4% cess ₹86,243
>
> Gross gain ₹1,12,840 Extra tax ₹44,643 Net gain ₹68,197
> Net gain as a percentage of the hike 60.4%, not 100%

Two lessons. First, a hike that crosses ₹12 lakh of taxable income is worth less than the percentage suggests, so plan for it rather than being surprised in March. Second, if you are close to the threshold, the structure of the increment matters: an amount routed through employer NPS, or spread differently across fixed and variable, can change the outcome. Ask HR to run the number before the letter is issued, not after.

What a 9.1% hike is actually worth, at eight salary levels

The percentage you keep is roughly one minus your marginal slab rate, plus 4% cess on that tax. At a 30% marginal rate you keep about 69 paise of every extra rupee; at 15% you keep about 84. The table shows that pattern, and then shows the two places where it breaks.

Taxable income now	After a 9.1% hike	Tax now	Tax after	Net gain	Net gain as % of hike
₹6,00,000	₹6,54,600	₹0	₹0	₹54,600	100%
₹9,00,000	₹9,81,900	₹0	₹0	₹81,900	100%
₹11,50,000	₹12,54,650	₹0	₹56,836	₹47,814	46%
₹11,80,000	₹12,87,380	₹0	₹76,031	₹31,349	29%
₹12,40,000	₹13,52,840	₹41,600	₹86,243	₹68,197	60%
₹15,00,000	₹16,36,500	₹1,09,200	₹1,32,392	₹1,13,308	83%
₹20,00,000	₹21,82,000	₹2,08,000	₹2,55,320	₹1,34,680	74%
₹30,00,000	₹32,73,000	₹4,99,200	₹5,84,376	₹1,87,824	69%

Computed on the FY 2026-27 new-regime slabs, with the Section 156 rebate and marginal relief applied, and 4% cess included. Taxable income is salary after the ₹75,000 standard deduction and before any other deduction. Figures rounded to the nearest rupee. This is an illustration, not tax advice; your actual liability depends on your full income and on the regime you elect.

The two breaks are the story. At ₹11.5 lakh of taxable income you pay no tax at all, because the Section 156 rebate wipes out the liability. A hike that carries you past ₹12 lakh turns the rebate off for the whole liability, not just the excess, and marginal relief only softens it. So the person earning ₹11.8 lakh keeps 29% of their hike, while the person earning ₹15 lakh keeps 83%. The second break is the relief band itself, which ends around ₹12.7 lakh of taxable income. Above that, the ordinary pattern resumes and the percentage you keep settles at one minus your marginal rate.

Eight lines to check on the increment letter

1. Revised CTC, and whether it is fixed CTC or total CTC including variable.

2. The full breakup, with basic as a percentage of CTC. Under the 50% wage rule this should now be at or near 50%.

3. The effective date, and whether arrears are payable if the letter is late.

4. Whether PF and gratuity have been recalculated on the new basic. If basic rose, they should have.

5. The variable target percentage, and the payout history for the last two years against it.

6. Designation and band, even if the money did not move. A band change is worth more next year.

7. Notice period and any bond or clawback attached to the increment or a retention bonus.

8. Whether any one-time payment in the letter is described as one-time. If it is, do not treat it as part of your base in your own planning.

9 The Promotion Case

One page, six boxes, and the questions to ask when the answer is 'next cycle'

Promotion is a separate decision from rating, usually with a separate budget, a separate approval chain and a committee that does not know you. Assuming that a strong rating produces a promotion is the most expensive assumption in Indian corporate life. Deloitte's 2026 survey found promotions running at about 14%, nearly twice the 7% share of top-rated performers, which means promotion is not simply a reward for being rated well. It is a decision about whether someone is already operating at the next level and whether the business needs another person there.

That has a direct consequence for how you ask. You are not asking to be rewarded for the past. You are showing evidence that the next level is already happening, and asking for the title and band to catch up.

Timing

Raise it two months before the cycle closes, in a dedicated conversation, not inside the appraisal form. If your cycle closes in April, that means February at the latest, which means the conversation you should be having is in the next few weeks. The conversation is not a demand; it is a request for the criteria and the process.

> **Opening the promotion conversation**
> "I want to be direct about something. I am targeting a promotion to [level] in this cycle. I would like to understand what specific evidence you need from me to support that recommendation, and what the approval process looks like on your side. I would rather build the right case now than find out in March that I was missing something."

The one-page case

Six boxes, one page, no adjectives. This is the document your manager will copy from when they write their recommendation, so make it copyable.

Box	What goes in it	Example
1. Target role and band	The exact designation and band you are asking for, and the effective date.	Senior Analyst, band B3, effective 1 April 2027
2. Evidence you already do it	Three items, each with a number, showing the work is already at that level.	Own the forecast for two regions; run the fortnightly forum; trained two joiners
3. The delta	What is genuinely missing, and how you will close it, by when. Naming this yourself is what makes the case credible.	Corporate-segment exposure. Shadowing the corporate review from January
4. The business reason	What changes for the company, not for you.	Removes a single-person dependency on the segment forecast
5. The risk	What happens if it does not happen, stated once, without drama.	I am at the top of my current band and would start looking externally in the next cycle
6. The ask	Title, band, effective date, and who needs to approve.	Band change now, money at the cycle, approved by the function head

The five types of evidence that survive a committee

1. **Scope.** You already manage something that belongs to the next level: a person, a budget, a client, a system, a region.

2. **Outcome.** A number that is yours, not the team's, and that someone outside your team has seen.

3. **Substitution.** You did the next-level job while the person holding it was away, and nothing broke. This is the strongest evidence there is, because it is a live trial.

4. **External proof.** A client, a vendor or a stakeholder saying it in writing. One sentence from outside the company outweighs a paragraph from inside it.

5. **Scarcity.** A skill or certification the team needs and only you hold. EY's 2026 data puts the premium on AI, machine learning, cybersecurity and cloud skills at 30% to 40%, and that premium exists inside companies as well as in the market.

If the answer is 'not this cycle'

This is the most common answer and the one people accept too quickly. Accept the answer and then ask four questions. Write the answers down in front of them, or send them a summary the same day.

1. What specifically is missing, in terms of evidence rather than adjectives?

2. Who decides, and what do they see?

3. What date will this be reviewed, and can we put it in the calendar?

4. If the title is blocked, is an acting allowance, a band change or a project lead role available in the meantime?

A promotion refused with four written answers is a plan. A promotion refused with a warm sentence is a deferral that repeats itself every year.

> **What a committee actually asks**
> Three questions, in this order: is the work already at that level, does the business need the role, and would we lose this person if we said no. Your one-page case should answer all three before anyone asks.

10 The Outside Option

Benchmarking properly, comparing offers on fixed pay, and what a counter-offer is really worth

An outside option is not a threat and it is not disloyalty. It is the reference point that makes your internal ask credible, including in your own head. The mistake is using it as leverage before it exists. The rule is simple: never mention an offer you would not accept.

Benchmark properly, in twenty minutes

One number from one website is not a benchmark, it is a coincidence. Use three sources, take the range, and note the date of each. For most Indian roles, the useful set is: a salary aggregator with self-reported data, a job board's published range for live postings of your exact title, and one conversation with someone who hired for the role in the last six months. For technology roles, levels-based sites add a fourth check.

- Search the exact title, not the family. 'Senior Analyst, FP&A;' and 'Analyst' are different markets.
- Filter by city and by years of experience, and by company type. A GCC in Hyderabad and a family-owned manufacturer in Ludhiana do not share a band.
- Write down the range, the median, the date you checked and the source. In a negotiation, 'AmbitionBox, checked this week, shows 9 to 11 lakh for this title in Pune' is an argument; 'I feel underpaid' is not.
- Ignore the outlier on both ends. Someone's ₹28 lakh claim for a ₹12 lakh role is either a different job or a different city.

Compare offers on fixed pay, not CTC

Two offers with the same CTC can differ by ₹1.5 lakh a year in your hand, and the difference is almost always in the four lines nobody reads. Fill this in before you decide anything.

Line	Offer A	Offer B	Current
Fixed pay (annual)			
Variable target % and last two years' actual payout %			
ESOP or RSU value, vesting schedule, cliff			
Joining bonus, and the clawback period			
Employer PF contribution and gratuity			
Health insurance: self, family, parents			
Notice period and buyout terms			
Location, commute and the real monthly cost of it			
Estimated monthly take-home			
Real hike against your current fixed pay			

Three rules of thumb. First, a joining bonus with a twelve-month clawback is a loan, not pay. Second, an unlisted ESOP is worth a range, not a number, and the range starts at zero. Third, a move that raises CTC by 20% but raises fixed pay by 6% is not a 20% raise, and it resets your tenure, your leave balance and your internal promotion clock.

When a counter-offer is real

Counter-offers are common in India and they are sometimes genuine. The test is not what is said in the room; it is what is written and dated. Ask for three things: the revised fixed pay in writing, an effective date inside the next payroll cycle, and the band or title change if the money is coming without one. If any of the three is missing, you are being bought time, not retained.

There is also a structural point worth understanding before you accept one. A counter-offer is usually funded from a retention budget, which is a different line from the increment pool. That means accepting it does not change your position in the next normal cycle; it just moves you once. If the underlying reason you looked was that your work was not being seen, a counter-offer does not fix that. It confirms the company can pay you, not that it will notice you.

Three questions to ask a new employer

- 'What did the last two increments in this team look like, as a percentage?' A company that cannot answer this has no increment culture, only a market adjustment when someone resigns.
- 'How is the variable component paid out historically — has it ever paid below target?' The answer tells you whether the variable is pay or a target.
- 'When was the last internal promotion in this team, and what did the person do to earn it?' This is the only reliable evidence about your own path.

> **The honest position**
> Looking is not betrayal, and staying is not weakness. The only bad option is the one where you neither look nor ask, and then discover in April that the market moved and you did not.

11 The Hard Cases

Nine situations that need a different script, not a better attitude

1. Your manager changed this year

Your new manager did not see your year and will rate you on their impression of a few months. The fix is early and unembarrassed: in your first month under them, hand over the brag document extract as context, not as a claim. 'So you have the history when the cycle comes' is a normal sentence. Then keep the five-line Friday going, because with a new manager it is doing more work than usual.

2. You are remote or hybrid and invisible

Distance does not reduce output, it reduces evidence. Three compensations: a weekly written note with one number in it, one artefact per quarter that leadership reads, and a deliberate request for cross-team work that puts your name next to someone senior. If your company is hybrid, ask directly whether your rating inputs include anything other than what your manager observed.

3. You are returning from maternity or paternity leave

Maternity benefit is 26 weeks of paid leave for the first and second child under the Code on Social Security, in force since 21 November 2025. Before you go, get three things in writing: how your targets will be pro-rated, how the appraisal cycle that falls inside your leave will be handled, and what the return-to-work plan looks like for the first ninety days. On return, ask for the rating criteria again, because the cycle you missed has changed the bar.

4. The role grew, the title did not

This is the most common and most fixable case, and it is a band problem rather than a performance problem. Do not argue for a percentage; argue for a band. 'My scope now includes the two regions and the forum, which is the B3 job description. I am being paid at B2 against a B3 scope. Can we correct the band, with the money following at the cycle?' A percentage on a B2 base is a smaller number for the same work, forever.

5. You got a rating you believe is wrong

Escalate the evidence, not the emotion. Ask for a meeting, bring the goals agreed at the start of the year and the evidence for each, and ask one question: 'What is the gap between this evidence and the expectations for the rating above?' Then stop and listen. If the answer is specific, you have next year's plan. If it is vague, say so once, calmly, and ask for it in writing. One escalation is professional. A second is a reputation, and it is not the one you want.

6. You are at the top of your salary band

In this case a percentage is structurally capped, and asking for one invites a lecture about the band. Ask for the three things that are actually available: a band change, a one-time payment, or a role change with a different band attached. Say the arithmetic out loud: 'I understand the band ceiling. Given that, what is the mechanism for the next band, and what would you need to see?'

7. 'Your work is good but leadership doesn't know you'

This is feedback about artefacts, not personality. Produce one thing a quarter that a person two levels up will read: a one-page analysis with a number in the title, a demo, a written recommendation with a decision in it. Then make sure your manager knows it exists, because forwarding is how it travels. Visibility is a distribution problem, not a charm problem.

8. Your manager will not advocate for you

First check the premise: ask directly, 'When you take my case into calibration, what will you say?' The answer tells you whether the problem is your evidence or their willingness. If it is willingness, the skip-level is legitimate, but the route matters: ask your manager's manager for a development conversation about the path to the next level, not a complaint about your manager. If the situation is chronic, the outside option in Part 10 is the real answer, and you should run it on your own timeline.

9. You are on a performance improvement plan

The first seven days decide the outcome. Get the plan in writing with measurable criteria and dates. Ask what 'met' looks like in numbers, not adjectives. Send a weekly written update against each criterion, so the record is yours. Do not sign anything you believe is inaccurate without noting your objection in writing. And check your notice period and any bond terms now, while you still have leverage and time, not in the week the plan ends.

> **The thread through all nine**
> Every one of these is solved by the same two things: an artefact in writing, and a specific question. Feelings do not travel through an organisation. Documents do.

12 Eight AI Prompts

Copy-paste prompts that do the drafting, so you can spend your time on the evidence

These are written for any current general-purpose assistant. Use them in order if you are starting from nothing: prompt 1 turns your notes into evidence, prompts 2 to 4 turn evidence into documents, prompts 5 to 8 prepare the conversations. Each one is designed to be pasted whole, with your notes appended.

Redact before you paste
Never paste a salary letter, an offer, a performance form or a client list containing PAN, UAN, bank details, customer names or unreleased financials into a public AI tool. Replace names with roles, replace exact figures with rounded ones where the exact figure is not needed, and strip identifiers first. If your company has an approved internal assistant, use that one.

1. Turn rough notes into brag entries

Prompt 1

You are helping me write performance evidence for a corporate appraisal in India. Below are rough notes about my year, in no order. Convert them into 12 entries using this formula: ACTION + NUMBER + SCOPE + LASTING EFFECT. Rules: one to two sentences each, past tense, no adjectives, no adverbs, never the phrases 'responsible for', 'helped with' or 'was involved in'. Where a number is missing, write [NEED NUMBER] at that point instead of inventing one. Sort the entries by business impact, highest first. Then list the five questions you would ask me to fill the gaps.

My notes: [paste]

What good output looks like: twelve entries you could paste into a form, plus a short list of the numbers you need to go and find. If it invents a number, stop and add the rule again.

2. Rewrite the self-appraisal in impact language

Prompt 2

Here is my draft self-appraisal. Rewrite it in impact language without changing any fact, keeping my voice and my first person. Keep it under 800 words. Structure: a 60-word opening that states my year and my self-rating claim; three to five achievements of 60 to 90 words each, each with one number; one 80-word paragraph on a real failure, owned, with the process that now prevents it and the evidence it works; one 60-word paragraph on how I worked with others; three goals for next year, each with a metric and a month. Do not add achievements I did not mention. List separately every place where my draft had an activity statement with no outcome, so I can fix it myself.

My draft: [paste]

What good output looks like: the same facts, tighter, with the weak sentences flagged rather than silently improved. The flag list is the useful part.

3. Find the missing numbers

> **Prompt 3**
> Below is a list of things I did last year, written as activities. For each one, tell me what number would make it an impact statement, where inside a typical company that number can be found (a dashboard, a ticket system, a finance report, a CRM, a calendar), and what a realistic order of magnitude would be. Do not invent my numbers. Give me a short interview: ask me one question at a time, and after each answer, propose the sentence I could write.
>
> My list: [paste]

What good output looks like: a list of places to look, not a list of guesses. This is the prompt that turns a weak appraisal into a strong one, because most people have the numbers and have never looked for them.

4. Write the one-page brief for your manager

> **Prompt 4**
> I need a one-page brief to send my manager before their calibration meeting. They have 15 people to represent and about two minutes each. Using my evidence below, write: a one-sentence story about my year that they could repeat from memory; three bullets with the number first and the explanation second; one line on the scope I now carry that I did not carry a year ago; and one line on what I am asking for in this cycle. Maximum 180 words total. No adjectives. Sound like a colleague, not a brochure.
>
> My evidence: [paste the brag entries]

What good output looks like: something you could send unedited in a chat message. If it reads like a cover letter, ask for it again in half the words.

5. Rehearse the pushback

> **Prompt 5**
> Role-play my manager in a salary conversation. My ask is [X], my evidence is [three bullets], my market data is [range and source]. Play the manager realistically: budget is fixed, the pool is about 9%, and they are sympathetic but constrained. Give me the five most likely objections, one at a time, and wait for my reply to each before giving the next. After all five, tell me which of my replies was weakest and rewrite it in two sentences.

What good output looks like: objections that sound like a real manager in an Indian company, and a critique of your weakest answer. If the objections are too easy, say so and ask for harder ones.

6. Build the promotion case

> **Prompt 6**
> Build a one-page promotion case for me in six boxes: target role and band; evidence I already operate at that level (three items, each with a number); the delta and how I will close it by when; the business reason in terms of what changes for the company; the risk if it does not happen, stated once without drama; and the specific ask. Under 350 words. Then list the three questions a promotion committee would ask that my case does not yet answer.
>
> My situation: [current role, target role, evidence]

What good output looks like: a page your manager can copy from, plus three uncomfortable questions. The questions are the value; answer them before you send anything.

7. Decode the increment letter

Prompt 7

Here is my increment letter with all personal identifiers removed. Explain every line in plain English, tell me which lines are fixed pay and which are contingent, calculate the percentage change in fixed pay separately from total CTC, flag anything that looks unusual or internally inconsistent, and list the questions I should ask HR before I accept. Use Indian income tax rules for FY 2026-27 under the Income-tax Act 2025 and say clearly where you are unsure.

The letter: [paste, redacted]

What good output looks like: two percentages, not one, and a list of questions. Verify anything about tax against the Income Tax Department's own pages before you rely on it; a language model is a useful first reader, not an authority.

8. Compare two offers honestly

Prompt 8

I have two offers and a current job. Below are the components of each. Compare them on fixed pay, on risk-adjusted variable pay, on the value of equity assuming the low end of any range, and on the real monthly take-home after tax and statutory deductions under the Indian new tax regime for FY 2026-27. Tell me what I am likely to be missing, what questions to ask each employer, and which single number I should optimise. Do not tell me which job to take.

Offer A: [paste]. Offer B: [paste]. Current: [paste].

What good output looks like: a table with fixed pay in the first column, and a short list of questions. If it recommends a job, delete that paragraph; the decision is yours and it involves things no model can see.

13 Templates and Worksheets

Print these, or copy them into a document you own

Worksheet A: the brag document

One row per entry. Keep it in your personal drive. Twelve filled rows is a strong year.

Month	What I did	The number	Scope	Lasting effect	Bucket	Evidence link

Worksheet B: the self-appraisal skeleton

Section	My draft
Opening (60 words): the year in one line, plus my self-rating claim	
Achievement 1 (60-90 words): action, number, scope, lasting effect	
Achievement 2	
Achievement 3	
Achievement 4 (optional)	
The challenge (80 words): what happened, the cost, what I own, the process now, the evidence	
Working with others (60 words)	
Three goals for next year, each with a metric and a month	
What I need (40 words, optional)	

Worksheet C: the one-page promotion case

Box	My case
Target role, band and effective date	
Evidence 1: I already operate at this level	

Box	My case
Evidence 2	
Evidence 3	
The delta, and how I close it, by when	
The business reason	
The risk if it does not happen	
The ask and who approves it	

Worksheet D: negotiation prep sheet

Fill this in before any money conversation. If you cannot fill a row, you are not ready.

Question	My answer
My current fixed pay, and my current total CTC	
The number I am asking for, in fixed pay	
My floor: the number below which I say no	
My three results, each with a number, in the order I will say them	
The scope I now carry that I did not a year ago	
My market range, the three sources and the date I checked	
The real-hike figure at current inflation	
My alternative if the answer is no (the seven asks, in order)	
The one question I will end with	

Worksheet E: the follow-up email

Send within four hours of the meeting

Subject: Summary of our conversation today

Hi [Manager],

Thank you for the discussion. To confirm what I understood: my rating for the year is [X], the increment position is [Y], and [Z] will be reviewed on [date].

The three points I raised were:
1. [Result with number]
2. [Result with number]
3. [Scope change]

If I have misrecorded anything, please correct me. I will follow up on [Z] on [date].

Regards,
[Name]

Worksheet F: the twelve-month tracker

Fifteen minutes a month. This is the mechanism that keeps the whole book working after today.

Month	One win, with a number	One thing I unblocked for someone else	One artefact I produced
November			
December			
January			
February			
March			
April			
May			
June			
July			
August			
September			
October			

Worksheet G: four questions before any money meeting

1. What is the single number I am asking for, and is it in fixed pay?

2. What is the smallest number I would accept without resentment? Say it out loud before you walk in.

3. Which three results am I leading with, in what order, and can I say each in one sentence?

4. What will I ask for if the answer is no, and in what order of preference?

14 The Thirty-Day Plan

Starting today, thirty days of work that changes what happens in April

The plan assumes you have one hour a week and one longer session at the start. It is deliberately small, because the failure mode of appraisal preparation is a heroic weekend in January that produces a document nobody reads.

Week	What you do	Time	Output
Week 1 (by 5 November)	The 45-minute reconstruction: calendar pass, sent-mail pass, documents pass. Then convert the best twelve stubs into brag entries.	60 min	12 brag entries
Week 2 (by 12 November)	Write the one-sentence story. Book the promotion conversation, or the 'what would need to be true' conversation if you are not chasing a promotion.	40 min	A booked meeting
Week 3 (by 19 November)	Benchmark: three sources, one range, dated. Fill Worksheet D completely.	45 min	Negotiation prep sheet
Week 4 (by 26 November)	Have the conversation. Send the follow-up email the same day. Note the answers verbatim.	40 min	The follow-up email
Then, monthly	Fifteen minutes on Worksheet F. One win, one unblock, one artefact.	15 min/mo	A live tracker
Two weeks before the form opens	Draft the self-appraisal from the tracker, not from memory. Send the one-page brief separately.	90 min	Self-appraisal + brief

What changes if you do nothing

Nothing dramatic, which is the problem. You will get something close to the average, because the average is the default. With a 9.1% projected pool and 5.54% inflation, the default outcome for 2027 is a real increase of about 3.4% before tax, and less than that in your hand. That is not a disaster. It is just what happens when a year is not written down, and it repeats.

The three things to do if you only do three

1. Write down twelve brag entries. Nothing else in this book substitutes for this.

2. Ask your manager, in a scheduled meeting, what would need to be true for you to be in the top band this cycle. Write the answer down.

3. Put a specific number on the table with a named source, and then stop talking.

> **One last thing**
> The person who reads your appraisal form has fifteen of them and a deadline. Make yours the one that is easy to defend, and make the defending sentence obvious enough that they do not have to compose it.

15 Sources and the Verification Log

Every figure in this book, with the publisher and the date it was checked

Checked on 29 October 2026. Where a figure comes from a survey, the survey's own release or first-party reporting of it is cited. Where a rule comes from a statute, the statute or the administering ministry is cited.

Figure used	Source	Date
India average salary increase 9.1% for 2026; sector table; 1,400 organisations, 45 industries	Aon, Annual Salary Increase and Turnover Survey 2025-26 India, 32nd edition	24 Feb 2026
2027 projection of 9.1% nominal; real wage growth 5.1% for 2027 against 4.3% for 2026; NBFC 10.1%, energy 9.9%, real estate 9.8%; Deloitte and WTW expecting flat; one-time bonuses replacing permanent hikes; banking 6-7% in FY27; top performers 2.24x variable pay and 1.85x salary increase; variable pay up to 40% of CTC at senior management	Mint reporting of Aon, Deloitte, WTW and ABC Consultants projections	20 Oct 2026
Highest-rating share 7% (from 10% in 2024); 16% in bottom two categories; promotions about 14%; 9.1% for 2026 against 9.0% for 2025	Deloitte India Talent Outlook 2026	6 Apr 2026
AI, ML, cybersecurity and cloud skill premium of 30-40%; top performers up to 1.6x through targeted rewards; 9.1% for 2026; GCCs 10.4%	EY Future of Pay 2026	23 Feb 2026
CPI inflation 5.54% for September 2026; food inflation 7.74%; rural 6.08%, urban 4.88%	Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, CPI release for September 2026	12 Oct 2026
Repo rate raised 25 bps to 5.50%; stance changed to calibrated tightening; FY 2026-27 CPI projected at 5.2% and about 5.8% across the next three quarters; core inflation 4.4%; next MPC 2-4 December 2026	Reserve Bank of India, Monetary Policy Statement 2026-27, 63rd MPC meeting	7 Oct 2026
New-regime slabs, ₹75,000 standard deduction, ₹60,000 rebate up to ₹12 lakh, marginal relief, 4% cess, surcharge cap; rebate now Section 156, new regime now Section 202	Income Tax Department and first-party analysis of the Income-tax Act 2025, in force 1 April 2026	Oct 2026

Figure used	Source	Date
Labour codes in force 21 November 2025; basic plus DA at least 50% of remuneration; excess allowances added back	Code on Wages 2019 and Ministry of Labour and Employment FAQ	Nov 2025 / Mar 2026
PF 12% with ₹15,000 wage ceiling; ESI ceilings; gratuity 15/26 with ₹20 lakh cap; employer NPS up to 14% of basic plus DA; combined employer PF, NPS and superannuation exempt to ₹7.5 lakh; maternity 26 weeks	Code on Social Security 2020 and 2026 employee benefits reference	Sep 2026

What is judgement, not data

- The scripts, templates and worksheets are mine. They are built on how Indian appraisal cycles work in practice, not on a published methodology.
- The advice on sequencing — benchmark, document, ask, follow up in writing — is judgement. It is consistent with what practitioners write, but it is not a controlled finding.
- The tax table in Part 8 is an illustration computed on the published slabs. It is not tax advice, and it ignores anything specific to your income, deductions or regime.
- Any recommendation to ask for a specific alternative when the budget is fixed is a judgement about what is usually available, not a claim about what your employer offers.

Re-verify before you rely on it

Two things in this book will go stale fastest: the salary survey figures, which are re-issued every February, and the tax position, which changes with each Budget. Before you use the market numbers in a real conversation, check the current survey release and note its date, because a number quoted without a date is a number your manager can dismiss.

Everything else — the templates, the prompts, the scripts, the calendar — will work in any cycle, because the underlying problem does not change. Work gets rated on what can be seen and defended. Your job is to make both easy.

One page to keep

If you print nothing else from this book, print this

Now (Oct-Nov)	Reconstruct twelve brag entries. Book the promotion or "what would need to be true" conversation.
December	Ask what would need to be true for the top band. Write the answer down.
January	Submit the self-appraisal early. Send the one-page brief separately, before calibration.
February-March	Nothing new lands. Calibration and budget lock. Ask only for a dated mid-year review.
April	Separate the rating conversation from the money conversation. Specific number, named source, then stop talking.
Same day	Send the five-line follow-up email summarising what was agreed.
Every Friday	Five minutes: what moved, what is blocked, what you need.

> **The sentence to carry into April**
> Your company has a 9% pool and inflation is 5.5%. You are not asking for a reward. You are asking for a correction, with your numbers attached. The only person who will make that case is you.

The 2027 Appraisal Playbook · Digitalaikart · Edition 2026-27
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